

competition from open source developers and free online-based services has pushed Microsoft to think innovatively and led to the introduction of Microsoft's Office Online office suite, which is truly a free offering. There are clear differences between Microsoft's Office Online and other cloud-based office suites simply based on the fact that Microsoft Office and Office Online have perfect compatibility with each other with the latter being free, making the choice for most customers very difficult.

The bulk of Microsoft's empire was built on selling consumers the licenses to its Windows operating systems and productivity tools such as the Office series. Now with the introduction of the Office Online suite, Microsoft



has challenged the rising competition. The ability to use Office applications that almost everyone is familiar with on any PC device through browsers can be considered a serious game changer in the world of office suites. This is

mainly because it will force other companies to provide better value to retain the customers they had originally poached from Microsoft.

The Online Office suite offers almost all the functionality of Office 365 without charging a dime. And with its browser-based platform, it can also be used on any OS without any degradation in functionality. This is more important than it may seem as many people are turning to their mobile devices such as tablets to work while on the go.

The Online Office suite is paired with Microsoft's OneDrive file storage system where all the work files get stored. The storage service has already found deep integration in the new Windows 8.1 operating system as well as through the use of a stand-alone desktop version. By leveraging the synchronicity between the two services, Microsoft is able to offer a great ease of transition to its users.

Online Office also distinguishes itself from Office 365 through its enhanced collaboration features at the same levels as Google Drive, with multiple collaborators being able to edit a single document simultaneously in real time. However, the Online Office suite has some clear limitations as it restricts the applications to Word Online (word processing), Excel Online (spreadsheets), PowerPoint Online (presentations) and OneNote Online, with the rest of Office 365's features being confined to the desktop versions.